

20 YEAR APOLOGY

Lincoln once had a close friend. It was NZ. One college day, they got into a little bit of drama in iMessage. Because of that, Lincoln decided to block NZ on everything out of the blue. 20 years into the future. Lincoln is living the dream. He enjoys being an Actuary, being one the best Actuaries in the country, making a lot of money from his job, and continuing connecting with the friends he made at college. He lives in a house made out of white, yellowish, and orange bricks located in the suburbs of Chicago, Illinois. He also has a family: a wife and two children named Dax and Gwen. One day, his kids are digging through a book full of old photos of Lincoln. The two notice that one picture was folded up. Unfolding it, they see another person in the picture with Lincoln. “Hey Dad!”

“Yes kids,” answers Lincoln. “What is it?”

“Why did you fold this photo up? Who is this standing right next to you? Was he a friend of yours?”

Looking at the picture, Lincoln feels a bit uncomfortable. “The... The photo wasn’t able to fit in the slot. So that’s why the photo was folded. The person next to me was a high school friend of mine. His name was... NZ.”

“NZ! The famous author that created The Bench Player?! You two were friends!!” Dax shouts. Gwen asks more questions, “Was he an amazing friend? Do you still talk to him?”

Sweat pours on Lincoln’s face. Lincoln replies with a simple nod. Then, they both suggest, “You should talk to him!”

“Oh no, Gwen. I think he is busy now,” says Lincoln. “I don’t want to interrupt him.”

The kids reply with a simple “okay.” However, inside of Lincoln, he feels bad for not telling his kids the truth.

Weeks later, Lincoln’s wife and children watch the news since NZ is going to discuss his new book and the purpose behind it. Lincoln enters the living room and sees them listening to NZ as he states a wise message, “No matter what your reason is, you are better off telling the person that you don’t want to continue the relationship than to just give them silence.” Lincoln’s wife and children adore the message and agree with NZ. Lincoln, out of nowhere, shouts, “Oh. please! You shouldn’t have to tell the person that you don’t want to continue the relationship. That’s just a waste of your time.” As Lincoln walks out of the room, NZ mentions a huge news that he will be in Chicago selling his new book and will give the audience the opportunity to get a flick and autograph from him. Everyone in the house jumps with excitement, except Lincoln. But on the inside, Lincoln feels remorse.

The day is here. NZ is in Chicago. Lincoln’s wife and children dress up fancy for the event. Before they left the house, Gwen heads to Lincoln and ask, “Dad. Why aren’t you going? Don’t you want to see NZ after 20 years?”

“First, I don’t have time. Second, I’m not interested in seeing him.”

Gwen got upset. “Why don’t you want to go and see NZ? Did he do anything wrong to you?”

Lincoln, keeping his calm, replies, “No. I just don’t want to see him at this time.”

A voice hollows through the halls. “Come on sweetie! We have to get going. If dad doesn’t want to go, then let it go.”

The child responds with a sad voice. “Okay Mom...” Lincoln, watching his child walking away from him, feels miserable and empty. While his family had fun, he stays home watching

Mushoku Tensei: Jobless Reincarnation. Lincoln isn't enjoying it because he can't stop thinking about NZ. So he hops to Youtube and watches an old interview that NZ had about getting blocked by a close friend. Watching the interview, he pauses the video after listening to how NZ felt betrayed by the act that his close friend did on him. Lincoln keeps holding onto the guilt, but he listens to NZ's feelings again. Repeating this 4 times, his mind got sick of holding the guilt. Lincoln had enough. "I am getting tired of holding on to the truth. I need to be a better role model for my children. I must apologize to NZ first." So Lincoln got into his own black Volkswagen car and drives to the event to make things right.

At the event, NZ hands out a lot of his books, signs autographs, and takes flicks with his fans. Lincoln's wife and children wait in line to greet him and get his new book. Gwen is still upset about Lincoln not coming here, but as the line continues moving forward, Gwen feels better and could see NZ closer. Lincoln finally arrives at the event. However, he is cautious to not get caught by his family. He wants to apologize to NZ privately so no one can see him. His body shakes nervously. His old belief tells him to not say sorry to NZ, but Lincoln fights back and keeps going. There in the distance, he sees NZ. NZ now has blonde hair, wears the new edition 2043 Ray-Ban sunglasses that are worth \$202.30, a maroon fedora hat, and a black suit with a Minnesota button-down shirt and a golden bow tie. Lincoln is amazed with the outfit that NZ is in and the crowd he gains, showing the growth and character he is now. Lincoln hopes that NZ can take a break so he can have a better chance at talking to him privately. Luckily, NZ decides to take a break now. He leaves the booth and heads down a hallway to go to the bathroom. Lincoln runs behind NZ quietly and waits five feet away from the bathroom. Meanwhile, Lincoln's wife and children are still waiting in line. Gwen needs to go to the bathroom badly and can't hold it anymore, so Dax and Gwen step out of the line and head to the

bathroom together. NZ finally got out of the bathroom. He sees a man standing by the bathroom and says a normal “Hi.” He doesn’t know that it is Lincoln. Lincoln stops NZ. “Hey NZ...,” he says in a whimpering tone.

Hearing the person's tone, NZ stops and checks on the person to see if he is okay. “Is everything okay sir?”

“Yes... But do you remember me NZ? It has been a long time.”

Looking at Lincoln for a long time, it clicks into NZ’s mind. “Oh my god... Lincoln. Is that you?”

Lincoln answers with a head nod. NZ got giddy to see and hear from Lincoln after 20 years. While NZ expresses how excited he is to Lincoln, Dax and Gwen are about to enter through the hallway that leads to the bathroom. Gwen notices Lincoln is with NZ at the far end. She tries to run to NZ, but Dax stops her and tells her to wait. NZ then asks Lincoln why he blocked him on everything. Lincoln spills his guts out to NZ with weepy tears. “I... I’m... I’m sorry for not telling you that I blocked you on everything. I really really am.” He continues on talking, explaining why he committed the act and didn’t tell NZ that he doesn’t want to continue the relationship. He lastly says, “I know that it has been twenty years since we talked and I do understand that you don’t want to be friends with me after what I did to you, but I hope that you can forgive my actions and aren’t mad at me still.”

He’s ready to face the yelling by NZ. But NZ is rather pleased than mad. He puts his hand on Lincoln’s left shoulder and states, “Lincoln... I have been waiting a long time for this apology. I am very happy for your bravery in telling me how you feel bad for blocking me and owning up to your actions.”

Lincoln's children watch from the far end of the hall and then walk towards Lincoln and NZ. "Dad," says Gwen. "Why are you crying?"

Lincoln puts his hands on Gwen and Dax. "Kids. I have to tell you the truth about me and NZ's relationship." Lincoln tells his children the honest true story that during college, he blocked NZ on everything without telling him and he didn't want to waste his time telling NZ he doesn't want to continue the relationship. He even apologizes to both of them for being a bad parent by lying to them and disagreeing with them unprofessionally. Hearing this, Gwen gets mad at first, but then hugs her dad as her way to indicate to Lincoln that she is proud of Lincoln. Dax, with a proud smile, tells his dad, "I'm happy for you dad."

"You'll always be a good role model to us dad even though you make mistakes," expresses Gwen.

Lincoln hugs his children back and happily cries for what his children tell him and finally spilling out his guilt. The crowd yells loudly, "We want NZ."

"I know that you have to go NZ, but can I ask you one thing quickly?"

"What is it?"

"Do you want to be friends again?"

"I'll have to think about it and tell you after the event. Meet me at this place when I'm done."

An hour later, the event ends. Lincoln and his family meet NZ at the spot he requested. NZ tells Lincoln, "As much as I would like for us to continue being friends even after what you did to me and 20 years later, I think it's for the best that we continue our solo journeys." Hearing the decision broke Lincoln. He feels like his apology was all for nothing. "However..." says NZ. "Since I can tell that you truly feel bad for what you did to me and lying to your kids, I will say

that we should hang out one last time. After all, I believe that this relationship deserves a proper and special send off.”

The next day, Lincoln and NZ head to Whirlyball to play Whirlyball, Lazer Tag, and Bowling. Playing these games bring flashbacks to when they have amazing times being together. After Whirlyball, the two old friends head to Marcus Theaters to watch Christopher Nolan’s first comedy film: *Charles Oppenheimer’s Hate On Oppenheimer*. Finally, they walk around Lincoln Park to gaze at the star, listen to Lake Michigan playing a beat against the rock, and watch the Canada Geese nibbling on grass.

Before NZ left. He gives Lincoln a gift. “What is this?” asks Lincoln.

“It’s a gift for you. Open it,” says NZ.

Lincoln opens the gift and it is NZ’s new book *Existential Loss*. “Why are you giving me this? You already know my family has a copy of this book.”

“I made this for you specifically. When you get to the end of the book, it has a special message.”

NZ is ready to leave. The two hug each other one last time and say last-minute words to each other. NZ drives off into the distance as Lincoln watches him. He tears up to see NZ go away and disappear in the fog. He looks at the last few pages of the book to see what the special message is about. Reading the message, Lincoln cries tears of gloom and joy. He then tells himself, “Even though we are no longer friends anymore, I am grateful that I got to hang out with NZ one last time. This is the true send off our relationship deserves. I am also glad that I was able to finally apologize to NZ even after twenty years. From now on, I will be a great role model to my children. Thank you for everything NZ.”

PROCESS STATEMENT

The point of view and tense form that I did was 3rd Person and present. I chose these forms because the story that I am writing focuses on my old close friend and the timeline takes place 20 years into the future. I was originally going to make this story a 1st and 3rd Person Point of View story, but while righting out the story, I felt like it would cause too much confusion for the reader. So instead of “I” referring to me, I used my name so it can make it easier for the readers.

Just like the Nonfiction Story that I wrote, craft elements that I applied here are using pseudonyms and participial phrases. Two elements I attempted adding in are personification, writing a present tense story, and making references to real events/pop culture. I want to add something new to my writing. I use personification to give objects human actions words (being more creative in my writing). When it comes to writing about something that involves me, I do like to write references to a movie or a real event. It is true that Charles Oppenheimer doesn't like Oppenheimer, hence the funny movie title.

My favorite part of the story is when Lincoln finally let out his guilt and owned up to his actions to me and his children. If I was in his shoes, I would totally feel the difficulty of bravely telling the person “I'm sorry”. This was Lincoln's big fiction moment. Besides the roadblock I mentioned at the beginning, another roadblock I encountered was making this story present tense. I fixed this by getting help from SWS to change past tense words to present tense. One thing I do wish I can include is one more obstacle for Lincoln to overcome, but the word count couldn't let me. So I keep the two that I have. Otherwise, I was concerned that I could over run the word count.

What made me inspired to write this piece is from an Inside Edition news video about a bully who wants to apologize to his victim in middle school after 20 years because he wants to set a good example to his kids. Being touched by this news, I want to make a fictional story about Lincoln apologizing to me 20 years later for his act of blocking me on everything. I do know that some may argue that this can ruin the ending of my Existential Loss Nonfiction Story I did earlier in the semester, however, I want people to primarily learn that it's never too late to apologize for your wrong doings and it's better to own it up than holding on to that guilt. I will admit, another thing that inspired my piece is the Thomas & Friends episode *Springtime For Diesel*. The episode follows Freytag's Triangle very well. Using this episode helps me structure the story while keeping the message I want to tell.